

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS: COLD OPEN

vo.5 (APPLIED, TO BE EVALUATED IN PLAY)

2026-09-14. The recut of vo.4's middle under spine v2.0.7 (ruled 2026-09-14): the key letter is a bare note, the letter behind the door clears the four, and the room turns on Liam within a month. Everything vo.4 ruled outside the middle is untouched: the first line, the sign-off, "They went that night, all four of them", "Only two of the friends are still alive, and neither one will say what that object was", the voice lessons (short lines, one fact per line, plain over crafted, never state the obvious). Stephen, 2026-09-14: "Good for now. I'll check everything when in the game." Applied that day to the chapter 1 graphs (PO1_03 to PO1_10) and to ch01.md, in place, no node added: the "worked the letter for weeks" and "within a month" sentences ride in PO1_07's first line ahead of "Then the group began to disappear"; the police ban rides in PO1_06's third line. Changed lines are marked ★. Word rulings happen in play. The jeopardy ruling of 2026-09-13 is the design: the danger is misdirected, not absent, and the open must let the listener believe a killer is one of the two on Ally's microphone.

What the recut must not do: state as Ally's knowledge anything she cannot source (she does not know whether anyone was ever in Violet's house); name the object; name what the letter said beyond clearing them, the intrusion and the doubt; break the Part H brief.

Checks to run when ruled: no em dashes · death in the first line, keys by about 0:35 · the changed lines against ch01.md and the chapter 1 graphs PO1_04, PO1_05, PO1_06 · Trish's plain-over-crafted rule.

This is Echoes of Havenbay. I'm Ally Quinn.

Nine months ago, a forty-four-year-old woman named Violet Moore was found dead at the bottom of her stairs.

Violet painted signs for a living. If you walked around this city, you'd see her work everywhere. Above shops. On boats. She even painted the side of a bus once.

Her death was ruled an accident. A terrible fall causing blunt force trauma to her head, nothing more.

But two weeks later, four people received something in the post.

Each of them got an identical key and a note written in Violet's handwriting. ★ (*was: a letter*)

Their names were Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera and Brad Collins. They were Violet's closest friends. ★ (*the accusation clause removed*)

The note told them to go to her store at the boatsheds. Together. All four of them. ★

It didn't say why. It said the four keys were the only ones. ★

The four friends called each other that night. They agreed that nobody would open the door alone. They went that night, all four of them.

And when they finally opened it, they found a letter. ★ (*was: another letter*)

It said someone had been getting into her house. ★

It said it wasn't any of them. ★

And it said she might be imagining it. ★

She also told them not to go to the police. ★ *(moved here from the key letter)*

There was an object beside it. Something that had belonged to Violet. Only two of the friends are still alive, and neither one will say what that object was.

They worked the letter for weeks at Ruby's kitchen table. ★

Within a month, the four of them were sure the person getting into Violet's house was one of them. ★

Then the group began to disappear.

Seven weeks after Violet's funeral, Brad drove to Kestrel Head, a place known for people who don't plan on coming home. His car was found there, but Brad never was.

Five months later, Margo's car appeared in the same car park. Three days after that, her body washed into the harbour.

That left Liam and Ruby.

They both went to the police. Separately. And each of them said the same basic thing.

I'm afraid of the other one.

Police examined Violet's letter and found no reason to believe it was fake. They looked into Liam. They looked into Ruby. They found nothing they could use. ★ *(letters → letter; singular, since the note says nothing)*

Now Liam and Ruby are accusing each other publicly, and a letter that cleared them both is tearing them apart as Havenbay takes sides. ★ *(was: Violet's warning)*

Ruby has agreed to speak with me. Liam hasn't. At least, not yet.

I don't know what was behind that locked door. I don't know whether anyone was ever in Violet's house. And I don't know whether Liam or Ruby has a reason to be afraid. ★ *(middle sentence changed)*

But four friends received four keys.

Nine months later, two of them are dead, and the other two believe one of them could be next.

So that's where we begin.

With Violet, her four friends and the door she wanted them to open.

This is Echoes of Havenbay, I'm Ally Quinn. Goodnight for now, Harbour. Sleep tight.

The graph mapping (chapter 1, once ruled)

Package	Old line	New line
PO1_04 line 1	"Their names were ... And according to the letter, one of them may have been planning to kill her."	"Their names were Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera and Brad Collins. They were Violet's closest friends."
PO1_04 line 2	"Violet didn't know which one. She admitted she might be wrong. But she was frightened enough to leave behind four keys."	"The note told them to go to her store at the boatsheds. Together. All four of them. It didn't say why. It said the four keys were the only ones."
PO1_05 line 1	"She also told her friends not to go to the police."	"And when they finally opened it, they found a letter. It said someone had been getting into her house."

Package	Old line	New line
PO1_05 line 2	"Instead, she directed them to a locked door. Behind it, she said, was the reason she had become afraid."	"It said it wasn't any of them. And it said she might be imagining it."
PO1_06 line 1	"The four friends called each other that night ... They went that night, all four of them."	Moves up to PO1_04's end or stays as PO1_06's first line, at Stephen's call on beat placement (the structure's turn rule: the reveal of the letter lands on a package completion)
PO1_06 line 2	"And when they finally opened it, they found another letter."	(absorbed above)
PO1_06 line 3	"This one didn't say she thought. It said she knew."	"She also told them not to go to the police."
PO1_06 line 4	"There was an object beside it ..."	unchanged
Later packages	"Police examined Violet's letters ..." / "Violet's warning is tearing them apart" / "I don't know whether Violet really identified her killer"	the three ★ lines above

Beat placement across packages 4 to 6 is a structure question (which completion the "found a letter" reveal lands on) and is settled in the structure v2.3 pass, not here.